get through a sleepless night, they are letting people into the stadium at 4am to try and squeeze 100,000 people in. Every space feels small, manic, with nowhere to allow yourself to feel at home.

I have started feeling back pain. It's a discomfort as much as anything, a dull ache to begin with, which is not completely unusual. I'm beginning to learn how the body expresses its unhappiness with you after a game. There are mornings I find it hard to sit down, to stand up, questioning whether a 24-year-old man should feel this old already in body, or whether in spirit I was always an old man in waiting. With each town, the discomfort slightly increases; Delhi, Faridabad, Margao, Kochi, Guwahati, Jamshedpur, Indore. We are losing heavily in foreign conditions and despite the pain increasing substantially with every game, I'm taking wickets; Sehwag, Pathan, Gambhir, Sehwag again, Yuvraj Singh, Suresh Raina, Sehwag a third time, Venugopal Rao, Vikram Singh. As I take each one, I'm beginning to not enjoy the wickets as I wince while I run, wondering what is wrong with me and wishing to be at home, where I can try to remember what painless cricket feels like.

Every time I leave the pitch, I feel like the child with the broken wrist who didn't want to mention the agony, fallen on the black ice in Burnley, laughed at as I gathered myself, leaving it until being forced to go to hospital by the teacher. I don't want to put anyone out or complain. It's a long tour and everyone is hurting. I can't kick the feeling that it is slightly unusual though. Every time I do mention it to the physio and the staff, he says it's because my front isn't strong enough. He keeps saying the best thing to do is to build up my front and back. He's positive it's about building up the rest of my body so that my back is not under so much pressure. In between every venue, the hurt increasing, I'm doing old school sit-ups and push-ups in my room, trying to build up my front. No matter what I do, the pain is unrelenting. Towards the end of the tour, the only thing I am looking forward to is the process of running in, because something happens in that run where pain vanishes and I glide through the air, before remembering that when I land on the other side, the feeling of nine times my body weight going through my front foot, I will be back in the world of the living, a pain pushing its crooked fingers through my spine, sending what feels like a disease spreading across my body.